

Gundam (Japanese: ガンダムシリーズ, Hepburn: Gandamu Shirizu; lit. Gundam Series) is a Japanese military science fiction media franchise. Created by Yoshiyuki Tomino for Sunrise (now a division of Bandai Namco Filmworks), the franchise features giant robots, or mecha, known as "Mobile Suits", typically including a prominent one carrying the name "Gundam". The franchise began with the premiere of the anime series Mobile Suit Gundam on April 7, 1979, which defined the "real robot" mecha anime genre by depicting giant robots (including the original titular mecha) within a militaristic setting. The popularity of the series and its merchandise spawned a multimedia franchise that includes over 50 TV series, films, and original video animations (OVAs), as well as manga, novels, and video games, along with a multimillion industry of plastic model kits known as Gunpla, which accounts for 90 percent of the Japanese character plastic model market. Academics in Japan have also taken interest in the series; in 2008, the virtual Gundam Academy was planned as the first academic institution based on an animated TV series. As of 2026, the Gundam franchise is fully owned by Bandai Namco Holdings through its anime production and distribution subsidiary Bandai Namco Filmworks (via Sunrise). The Gundam franchise had grossed over \$5 billion in retail sales by 2000. In the first quarter of fiscal year 2026 (April–June 2025), the Gundam franchise generated approximately ¥65.4 billion (approximately US\$443 million) in IP-related revenue, making it Bandai Namco's highest-earning intellectual property during that period, driven by successes across streaming, model kits, theatrical releases, and experiential tourism initiatives.

**Overview**

**Concept**

Mobile Suit Gundam was developed by animator Yoshiyuki Tomino alongside rotating members of Sunrise using the collective pseudonym Hajime Yatate. The series' early working title was Freedom Fighter Gunboy, reflecting the robot-centric focus and adolescent target demographic. Conceptual elements like naming the White Base "Freedom's Fortress", the Core Fighter "Freedom Wing", and the Gunperry "Freedom Cruiser" underscored the theme of freedom. The name Gundam was eventually chosen—combining “gun” and “dam”—to evoke imagery of a powerful weapon acting like a dam to hold back enemies. Gundams are portrayed as prototype or limited-production mobile suits with superior performance compared to mass-produced models. These suits typically feature humanoid designs, cockpit control in the torso, and head units functioning as visual sensors. Across the franchise's numerous series and media formats, each Gundam variant reflects unique aesthetics, capabilities, and pilots.

**Innovations to the genre**

Mobile Suit Gundam is credited with pioneering the real robot subgenre of mecha anime, distancing itself from the fantastical “super robot” scene by introducing realistic mechanics, energy limitations, and equipment failures. The franchise integrates plausible science—such as Lagrange points, O'Neill cylinder colonies, and helium-3 energy—with speculative constructs like Minovsky physics to support its mechanics. Its sweeping narratives and political dimensions also align it with the space opera genre. A recurring theme includes genetically advanced humans known as Newtypes, endowed with extrasensory perceptions that enhance piloting capabilities and interpersonal empathy.

**Timelines**

The Gundam franchise is subdivided into "timelines" which act as their own self-contained continuities. The largest of these continuities is the Universal Century (UC), which began with the original show from 1979. Alternate universes such as the Cosmic Era (e.g., Gundam SEED) and the Anno Domini era (e.g., Gundam 00) present standalone narratives. While they may take inspiration from each other, they ultimately represent their own chronology.

**Spinoffs**

SD Gundam employs a comedic style with chibi characters, debuting in the mid-1980s. Later series such as Gundam Build Fighters and Gundam Build Divers explore modern-day settings where battles between Gunpla (model kits) serve as the central narrative device.

**Media**

**TV series, films, and video**

Except for Mobile Suit Gundam 00, which follows the current calendar era albeit three centuries in the future, all Gundam series are set in a fictional era, with a new calendar adopted after a drastic event or chain of events and typically involving a major conflict involving Earth and space colonies (and in some cases the Moon and terraformed planets). An exception are the Gundam Build timelines, which are set in an alternate present time where all other Gundam installments are fictional.

**Manga and novels**

Manga adaptations of the Gundam series have been published in English in North America by a number of companies, such as Viz Media, Del Rey Manga and Tokyopop, and in Singapore by Chuang Yi. Notable entries include Mobile Suit Gundam: The Origin, written and illustrated by original series character designer Yoshikazu Yasuhiko. It is a retelling of the first series with additional flashbacks surrounding one of the series' main characters, Char Aznable.

**Video games**

Gundam has spawned over 80 video games for arcade, computer and console platforms, some with characters not found in other Gundam media. Some of the games, in turn, inspired spinoff novels and manga.

**Gunpla**

Primarily made of plastic, but sometimes paired with resin and metal detail parts, hundreds of Gundam scale plastic models, known as Gunpla, have been released since the early 1980s. They range in quality from

toolless-build children's toy kits (Entry Grades) to hobbyist and museum-grade models, and most are in common scales such as 1:35, 1:48, 1:60, 1:100, or 1:144. Various Grades exist to target hobbyists, ranging from smaller-sized kits such as High Grade and Real Grade to larger Master Grade and Perfect Grade model kits. The Real Grade (RG) Gundam series combines the Master Grade's detailed inner structure with additional color separation, making the 1:144-scale series complex in design and compact in size, with the final goal of retooling a Gundam to what it might look like in real life, similar to the full-size Gundam statues.

Promotional 1:6 or 1:12 scale models are supplied to retailers and are not commercially available. For Gundam's 30th anniversary, a full-size RX-78-2 Gundam model was constructed and displayed at Gundam Front Tokyo in the Odaiba district; it was taken down on March 5, 2017. A new statue of the RX-0 Unicorn Gundam was erected at the same location, now renamed The Gundam Base Tokyo.

Other merchandise

Bandai, Gundam's primary licensee, produces a variety of products. Other companies produce unofficial merchandise, such as toys, models and T-shirts. Products include Mobile Suit in Action (MSiA) action figures and Gundam model kits in several scales and design complexities. Each series generally has its own set of products, MSiA and model lines such as Master Grade and High Grade Universal Century, which may extend across series. The most popular action figure line has been the Gundam Fix series, which includes the mecha in the animated series, manga, novels and accessories to create an updated version. In addition to Master Grade and High Grade Gundams, Bandai released a 30th-anniversary series of Gundam models in 2010. After the introduction of the RG Gunpla line, Bandai released the Metal Build series in March 2011, beginning with the 00 Gundam.

Online engagement

Bandai Namco Filmworks maintains several official websites to promote Gundam projects. The main Japanese-language portal is Gundam Perfect Web, which provides news, product information, and event updates.

In July 2025, Bandai Namco Filmworks announced that the longstanding portal Gundam.info is undergoing a major overhaul, to be rebranded as the Gundam Official Website. This new site, to be hosted at gundam-official.com Archived October 8, 2025, at the Wayback Machine, is slated to launch in 2025 and will serve as the international hub for series information, news, and product updates, replacing Gundam.info.

In 2005, Gundam.info's English counterpart hosted the Gundam Official User Forum, which was based on the fan-run Gundam Watch forum and used many of its moderators. After the forum's closure, Gundam Watch re-emerged independently as Gundam Evolution.

Series-specific promotional websites have also been created to highlight character info, mecha designs, merchandise, and special content like wallpapers or mini-games. For example, the Superior Defender Gundam Force site featured an interactive game where the player takes control of Commander Sazabi in a comedic scenario.

The franchise also maintains an active presence on social media platforms, including Twitter, Instagram, YouTube, and TikTok, where official accounts post trailers, Gunpla showcases, news updates, and livestream content aimed at fans worldwide.

Global spread

Gundam began expanding beyond Japan in the early 1980s through television broadcasts and home-video distribution across East and Southeast Asia, followed by Europe and the Americas in the 1990s, aided by Bandai's international licensing and merchandise programs. In North America, mainstream recognition increased dramatically in 2000 when Mobile Suit Gundam Wing premiered on Cartoon Network's Toonami block; industry trade coverage at the time noted Toonami's rising kids' ratings and cited Gundam Wing as a key acquisition driving the block's expansion that year. Subsequent home-video partnerships widened catalog access in the mid-2010s, including Sunrise's 2014 distribution agreement with Right Stuf/Nozomi for legacy Gundam titles in North America. In Europe, the brand's visibility has been reinforced by major pop culture events, with media in France highlighting Bandai hobby exhibits and large-scale Gunpla activations at Japan Expo in Paris. More recently, global streaming has accelerated international reach; for example, Netflix announced a worldwide debut for the Unreal Engine-produced series Gundam: Requiem for Vengeance, underscoring the franchise's contemporary, simultaneous release strategy outside Japan. Collectively, these developments—broadcast exposure, hobby merchandising, event marketing, home-video partnerships, and day-and-date streaming—have driven the franchise's sustained overseas growth and helped standardize access to both classic catalog and new installments.

Impact

Gundam is a Japanese cultural icon and a multi-billion-yen annual business for Bandai Namco. Annual revenue for the franchise reached ¥54.5 billion by 2006, ¥80.2 billion by 2014, and ¥145.7 billion by 2024. Examples of its cultural ubiquity in the country include the issuing of Gundam stamps, an Agriculture Ministry employee being reprimanded for contributing to Japanese Wikipedia Gundam-related pages, and the Japan Self-Defense Forces code-naming its developing advanced personal-combat system Gundam. Based on a December 16, 2023 survey conducted by Nikkei Entertainment, the fanbase of Gundam within Japan has an average age of 42 years, and a male-to-female ratio that skews 90:10. The impact of Gundam in Japan has been compared to the impact of Star Wars in the United States.

See also

Bandai Museum

Mobile Suit Gundam

Gundam (fictional

robot))\n\n\n== References ==\n\n\n== External links ==\n\n\nOfficial website\nOfficial website (in Japanese)\nGundam (anime) at Anime News Network's encyclopedia\nGundam at the MAHQ website\nGundam Perfect Games (in Japanese)\nBandai Visual's Gundam minisite Archived December 4, 2016, at the Wayback Machine (in Japanese)